MoveInSync Play Store Ratings: Diagnosis & Action Plan

Forward Deployed Engineer (Intern to FTE) - Case Study Submission

Data as of 10 October 2026 | App: com.moveinsync.ets

4.32	114,500+	~3.0	12%
Global Rating	Total Ratings	30-day Avg	1-Star Share

Tools: Claude (AI), AppBrain, Google Play Store, Python + google-play-scraper

All data sourced from publicly available sources.

1. Bottom Line

The headline rating (4.32) hides a split audience: ~86% of raters give 4-5 stars and ~12% give 1 star - with almost nobody in between. The 1-star group is not complaining about looks. It is angry about four trust-breaking failures in the core commute loop: No Show marking, broken bookings, unreliable tracking, and OTP/boarding friction.

The trend matters more than the level. Between a late-July snapshot and 8 October, the lifetime score slipped from 4.36 to 4.32 while ~3,200 new ratings arrived - implying recent ratings average only ~3 stars. Two things coincide with the slide: the UI redesign (12.x releases, July-September 2026) and newly added verification steps.

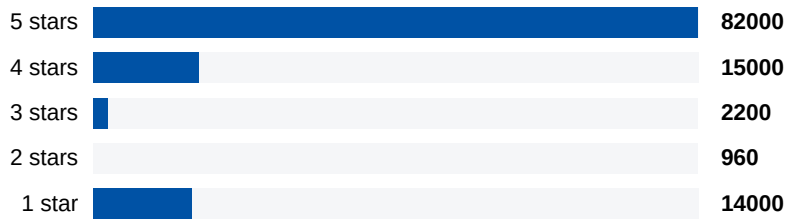
Priority Order - Do These First:

P0-1	Fix No-Show fairness - add a pre-miss alert and a one-tap dispute in the app
P0-2	Fix booking date/state bugs - wrong dates, 'not booked' notifications
P0-3	Make live tracking trustworthy - staleness alerts, freeze ETA changes with notification
P0-4	Make OTP always reachable - never block boarding at the cab door
P0-5	Release guardrail - staged rollout with halt rule on every release

2. Where the Ratings Stand

Metric	Value	Source
Play Store rating (global)	4.32 from ~114,500 ratings	AppBrain, 8 Oct 2026
Rating on a typical phone	4.6 (device-specific view)	Play Store screenshot
iOS App Store rating	4.7 from ~470 ratings	AppBrain
Competitors (Play)	Routematic 3.8 | eFmFm 3.5	AppBrain
5-star count	~82,000 (72%)	AppBrain histogram
4-star count	~15,000 (13%)	AppBrain histogram
3-star count	~2,200 (2%)	AppBrain histogram
2-star count	~960 (1%)	AppBrain histogram
1-star count	~14,000 (12%)	AppBrain histogram

Star Distribution (AppBrain histogram)



Key insight: The distribution is U-shaped. Addressing 1-star raters is where all the leverage is. If the 1-star share halves (12% to 6%) and those users give 5 stars instead, the average rises by ~0.25 to roughly 4.55 - an attainable upper bound.

3. Why the Ratings Are Where They Are

Evidence: ~25 Play Store review excerpts (June-October 2026), AppBrain comments, App Store and G2 reviews (2023-2026), and MoveInSync's own help-center release notes.

Root Cause 1: Unfair or Surprising "No Show" Marking

- Users marked No Show despite having booked, or after a late vehicle arrives.
- One review reports a salary deduction penalty - highest emotional severity of any complaint.
- June 2026 review: asks for a reminder once the vehicle passes the pickup point.
- 2023 iOS review asks for a user-side No Show option - this issue has been open for years.
- Release notes: driver-app fix (location check + timer + reason selector) exists, but whether the employee sees any of it is unclear from reviews.

Root Cause 2: Bookings That Do Not Match Intent

- Users select specific dates and get bookings for other dates.
- Booked trips keep triggering 'trip not booked' notifications (state mismatch).
- Shuttle booking redesigned to two steps - users thought cab was booked when it was not.
- July 2026 review directly attributes booking confusion to the 12.x redesign.

Root Cause 3: Tracking, ETA and Pickup Time Cannot Be Trusted

- Theme appears in every year sampled (2023-2026) - a long-standing systemic issue.
- Complaints: slow/wrong GPS, inaccurate ETA, pickup times that keep changing without notice.
- Shuttle live location removed after a recent update.
- Play's own AI review summary lists 'Navigation Accuracy' with 133 topic mentions.
- Other riders' live location not visible on shared shuttle trips.

Root Cause 4: Friction at the Cab Door (OTP / Boarding)

- September 2026 reviews: seat-belt verification is broken and blocks the entire boarding flow.
- OTP disappears behind the seat-belt check modal - rider cannot show OTP to driver.
- OTPs not arriving on some devices at login.
- A rider who cannot show an OTP cannot board - highest real-world operational impact.

Root Cause 5: Release Management and Stability

- 12.x redesign shipped with no staged rollout or per-version rating guardrail.
- Complaints: small Book tab, red Logout styled like Cancel, confusing layout with no warning.
- Cab view shows every available cab - not just the user's assigned vehicle.
- Reports of crashes, stuck startup screen, and no cached ride details (network call on every open).
- Rolling out UI changes without a halt rule turns every release into a rating risk.

Cross-Cutting Factor: Ops Problems Get Blamed on the App

- Some 1-star reviews are about the service (late cabs, crowded cabs, ignored complaints to transport desk).
- The app is the only visible place to vent - riders have no better channel.
- Fix: in-app 'Report a problem with this trip' button, routed directly to the transport desk.

4. What to Do - Priority Action Plan

Every item below is specific enough for a product or engineering team to start the next working day. Owners and success metrics are included for each fix.

P0-1	Make No Show Fair and Visible
(a) Push 'Your cab is at/near pickup - check in now' when vehicle enters a set radius, and again at pickup time. (b) Show the No Show reason, driver location at time of marking, and a one-tap dispute button in the employee app. (c) Block No Show marking when vehicle ETA is late or the location check fails. Verify 6.4.0 driver-app rules are active for all clients.	

Owner:

P0-2	Fix Booking Correctness
(a) Reproduce the wrong-date bug (check date-range selection and timezone handling). Add a confirmation screen listing exact dates, direction, and vehicle type before submit. (b) Find why 'not booked' notifications fire for booked trips (state mismatch between booking and notification services). (c) Revert shuttle booking to one step, or add a clear 'Confirmed' state that is visible.	

Owner:

P0-3	Make Tracking Trustworthy
(a) Log 'age of last location ping' per active trip; alert ops when above 30 seconds. (b) Show 'Updated 12 s ago' on the map so riders can see when data is stale. (c) Restore shuttle live location that was removed in recent update. (d) Freeze pickup-time changes silently - send a notification to the rider with a reason. (e) Check driver-app battery optimisation and ping interval on low-end phones.	

Owner:

P0-4	Never Block Boarding
(a) Keep OTP always visible on the trip screen - never hidden behind other modals. (b) Add OTP fallbacks: resend option, voice call, in-app display. (c) Make seat-belt verification non-blocking when it fails. Log all failures for investigation.	

Owner:

P0-5	Release Guardrail on Every Build
Use Play staged rollouts (5% -> 20% -> 50% -> 100%) with a halt rule: if crash rate, ANR rate, or 1-star share of new ratings per version exceeds the previous release, pause the rollout immediately. Put big UI changes behind feature flags. Add 'What's new' in-app notes on first open after any update.	

Owner:

P1-6	Stability and Offline Basics
Check Play Console Android Vitals and Crashlytics for top crashes and the startup loop. Cache the last trip so the app opens without a network call. Stay under Play's bad-behaviour thresholds for crash rate and ANR rate.	

Owner:

P1-7	
On the trip screen, show the user's assigned cab first and hide other available cabs by default. Add a 'Show all' toggle for ops/admin users who need it.	
	Owner:

P1-8	Reply to Every Low-Star Review
Reply to every 1-2 star review within 48 hours using three templates (booking, tracking, No Show). Include an escalation path. Ask users to update their rating after a fix is shipped. Note: No developer replies were seen in the sampled reviews. Verify this in Play Console.	
	Owner:

P2-9	Better Moment to Ask for a Rating
Trigger the Play in-app review prompt only after a successfully completed trip - never after a No Show or failed booking. Add an internal 'Report a problem with this trip' button on the post-trip screen, with tenant ID attached, so ops issues route to the transport desk instead of the Play Store. Do not filter who sees the Play prompt by sentiment - this violates Play policy.	
	Owner:

P2-10	Review Ops-Driven Complaints per Client
Tag reviews as 'app-fixable' or 'ops-related'. Share the ops tags monthly with account teams of clients whose employees complain most.	
	Owner:

5. Execution Roadmap & Expected Impact

Week 1-2 | Ship P0 fixes

- P0-1: No-Show alert + one-tap dispute flow (Backend + Android)
- P0-2: Booking confirmation screen + state-mismatch bug fix (Backend)
- P0-3: Ping-age logging + 'Updated Xs ago' label on map
- P0-5: Staged rollout process and halt rule in place for all future releases
- P1-8: Begin replying to all 1-2 star reviews within 48 hours

Week 3-4 | Complete P0, Begin P1

- P0-3: Shuttle live location restored; pickup-time freeze + rider notification
- P0-4: OTP always visible + fallbacks (resend, voice); seat-belt non-blocking
- P1-6: Top crash and startup-loop fixes from Android Vitals and Crashlytics
- P1-6: Last-trip cache so app opens instantly without a network call

Month 2 | P1 + P2

- P1-7: Trip screen shows only user's assigned cab first by default
- P2-9: Post-trip rating prompt + in-app 'Report a problem' button live
- P2-10: Ops-vs-app tagging system + first monthly report to account teams
- P1-8: Reply-rate dashboard tracking; target 80%+ reply rate maintained

Month 3+ | Sustain & Monitor

- Weekly playstore_pulse.py report reviewed every Monday morning
- Per-version rating dashboard live in Play Console for all releases
- Ongoing target: new-ratings average at or above 4.3; 1-star share below 8%
- Ops tagging report shared monthly with Customer Success team

Expected Impact

Metric	Current	Target	Timeline
30-day avg rating	~3.0 stars	4.3+ stars within 60 days of P0 ship	4-6 weeks
1-star share	~12%	Below 8% of new ratings	6-8 weeks
Lifetime rating	4.32	4.55+ (upper bound if 1-star halves)	12-18 months
OTP boarding fails	Unknown	Below 0.1% of trips	4 weeks
Crash-free users	Unknown	Above 99.5%	3-4 weeks
Review reply rate	~0% (sampled)	Above 80% on 1-2 star reviews	2 weeks

6. Answering "How Are Our Play Store Ratings?" Every Week

This is not a one-time ask. A reusable Python script (playstore_pulse.py - see Section 7) runs every Monday and prints the same 6-line standard answer automatically, saving a JSON snapshot for week-on-week trending.

1	Global rating and total count, and change versus last week.
2	Rolling 30-day average rating and 1-star share of new ratings.
3	Rating by app version - to catch a bad release in days, not months.
4	Top 5 complaint themes this period and change versus last period.
5	Reply rate and median reply time on 1-2 star reviews.
6	One sentence: what changed and what we are doing about it.

* Support / ops

* Crash / performance

Ideal next step: Connect Play Console's Reviews API or set up a Slack webhook so every new 1-star review reaches the product team the same day - not the following Monday.

7. playstore_pulse.py - Recurring Monitoring Script

The full script is provided as a separate file (playstore_pulse.py, attached).
Install dependencies: pip install google-play-scraper pandas tabulate
Run weekly: python playstore_pulse.py

Output: 6-line standard answer, JSON snapshot for trending, tagged CSV of all fetched reviews.

Config and Theme Keywords:

```
APP_ID       = "com.moveinsync.ets"
MAX_REVIEWS  = 500
ROLLING_DAYS = 30

THEME_KEYWORDS = {
  "No Show / penalty":    ["no show", "penalty", "deducted", "check in"],
  "Booking / date bug":   ["booking", "date", "wrong date", "not booked"],
  "Tracking / GPS / ETA": ["tracking", "gps", "location", "eta", "pickup time"],
  "OTP / login / safety": ["otp", "seat belt", "verification", "cannot board"],
  "UI / redesign":        ["ui", "layout", "confusing", "redesign"],
  "Crash / performance":  ["crash", "slow", "freeze", "not opening"],
  "Support / ops":        ["driver", "support", "transport desk"],
}
```

Core: 6-Line Standard Answer (printed each Monday):

```
def print_standard_answer(meta, rolling, prev, ver_df, themes, reply):
    print(f"1. Global: {meta['score']}  ({meta['ratings']:,} total ratings)  [delta vs last week]")
    print(f"2. 30-day avg: {rolling['avg']}  |  1-star share: {rolling['one_star_pct']}%")
    print("3. Rating by version (recent):")
    print(tabulate(ver_df, headers='keys', tablefmt='simple', showindex=False))
    print("4. Top themes (low-star reviews):", themes[:5])
    print(f"5. Reply rate: {reply['replied']}/{reply['total_low']}  ({reply['rate_pct']}%)")
    print(f"6. Trend: {trend}  |  Top complaint this week: '{themes[0][0]}'")
```

Snapshot for Week-on-Week Trending:

```
# Saved to pulse_snapshots/snapshot_YYYY-MM-DD.json each run
```

```
snapshot = {
    "date":                   today,
    "global_rating":          meta.get("score"),
    "total_ratings":          meta.get("ratings"),
    "rolling_30d_avg":        rolling["avg"],
    "rolling_30d_one_star_pct": rolling["one_star_pct"],
}
```

8. Method, Tools and Assumptions

How I Got Here

Read the case brief -> pulled Play Store listing, histogram, and sample reviews -> used AppBrain for rating counts, star distribution, competitor ratings, and recent comments -> read App Store and G2 reviews to check which complaints are long-standing -> read MoveInSync help-center release notes for the No Show driver-app changes -> corroborated themes with Play's own AI review summary and topic chips in screenshots provided.

Tools Used

Tool	Used For
Claude (AI)	Search, synthesis, drafting, structuring
AppBrain	Rating counts, star histogram, competitor data
Google Play Store	Review excerpts, AI summary, topic chips (133 mentions GPS)
Python + google-play-scraper	Recurring automated weekly pipeline (playstore_pulse.py)
G2 + iOS App Store	Cross-platform long-standing issue validation (2023-2026)
MoveInSync Help Center	Release notes - No Show driver-app location check changes

Limits and Assumptions (Please Read)

- Could not download the full review corpus - the public Play page shows only three reviews without scrolling, and the API requires authentication. Themes come from ~25 reviews plus AI summary, not a statistical sample. Run playstore_pulse.py to confirm and rank themes before committing to the order of work.
- 'Recent ratings average ~3 stars' is derived from two third-party snapshots (4.36 at 111,326 ratings in late July; 4.32 at 114,497 ratings on 8 October). Treat it as a warning sign, not a precise measurement.
- Histogram figures are AppBrain's rounded numbers. The weighted mean (4.31) matches the reported 4.32, which supports reading them in 5-to-1 order.
- Reviews do not say which client company the rider belongs to. Some complaints may be specific to one customer's ops configuration rather than the app itself.
- Play reportedly weights recent ratings more heavily than a plain average - the visible score should improve faster than lifetime arithmetic suggests, but this could not be independently verified. Treat faster movement as a possibility, not a guarantee.